

Imagine a cable channel dedicated to gardening. Throughout the day, you can learn about landscape architecture, hear discussions on which plants work best in what climates, learn to create compost, get advice on fertilizers, weed killers, and pesticides. Want to maintain your perennials, annuals, or topiary? Build a greenhouse? All are regular segments. It's inexpensive to produce and relaxing to watch.

The channel's website has remote webcams watching trees grow. Any day you visit the site looks more or less like the previous one. Perhaps every six or 12 months, you might notice some progress on the growth.

Then, a private equity fund buys the channel. The pastoral, ASMR-like broadcast doesn't work for the new owners. They need to attract eyeballs, sell advertising, ramp up viewership numbers. *Not enough people were tuning in*, and they want to flip the property for a profit.

So they rebrand The Gardening Channel with flashy graphics, sound effects, and sexy anchors. Artificial conflicts used to create the dynamic tension all good narratives require—AKA classic reality TV—becomes the focus.

Guests are scheduled so disagreements occur. Viewers see many different gardening approaches, including some that don't work especially well. Arguments over *the* webcam tree (*Not this one, that one!*) are plentiful; the tree was planted too deep (*No! Too shallow!*); it should be there (*No, here!*). They yell about too much or too little watering, what types of fertilizer to use, how much it should be trimmed back each season.

Instead of bucolic imagery, it's now all debates, arguments, and criticism. "Big Garden is repressing the landscape!" It has become an MMA cage match of faux disagreements about flora.

Viewership soars, despite a simple truism: Nothing that ever gets said makes a damn bit of difference to that tree. It just quietly keeps growing over time...

